

Dhāraṇī of the Great Black Goddess

Devī Mahākālī Nāma Dhāraṇī · Toh 670 · Derge Kangyur

ལྷ་མོ་རྒྱ་མ་ཚེ་མའོ་གཟུངས།

The Dhāraṇī of the Great Black Goddess, known in Sanskrit as the Devī Mahākālī Nāma Dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as Lhamo Nagmo Chenmo'i Gzungs, is a short dhāraṇī text centered on the fierce goddess Mahākālī, a powerful female deity associated with the desire realm who is described as the Mother of Māra and Sister of Yama. The text takes the form of a canonical sūtra opening, with the goddess approaching the newly awakened Buddha beneath the Bodhi tree and offering him her vidyā, a sacred spell or mantra, which he in turn accepts and proclaims to the assembly. It belongs to the dhāraṇī literature of the Buddhist canon, a genre dedicated to the preservation and transmission of protective and efficacious ritual formulas. This text is Toh 670 in the Kangyur, found among the collections of dhāraṇīs that form a distinct and widely represented class within that scriptural treasury.

In the language of India: Devī Mahākālī Nāma Dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: the dhāraṇī of the Great Black Goddess.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, not long after the Blessed One had fully and perfectly awakened, he was dwelling at the foot of the tree of awakening. Then the Mistress of the desire realm (kāmadhātu), the Mother of Māra, the Sister of Yama, the Great Black Goddess, circumambulated the Blessed One three times and sat down to one side.

Having done so, the Great Black Goddess addressed the Blessed One with this request: "Venerable Blessed One, if I were to offer the vidyā that pays homage at your feet, may the Blessed One please accept it."

Then the Blessed One declared: "Let the Great Black Goddess, Mother of Māra and Sister of Yama, bind all above up to and including the gods who delight in wielding the creations of others. Let her bind all below down to and including the hell-beings. And let her bind all around her in every direction up to and including the mountains. And let these mantras of hers be recited:

tad yathā: oṃ ru ru bitiṣṭha vadhōtsi ru ru ro ru bitiṣṭha vadhōtsi svāhā.

By the recitation of this, all epidemic diseases, illnesses, non-human spirits, every kind of fault, leprosy, eye diseases, skin diseases,

Translator's Notes

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end of the passage provided, ending with a list of afflictions that the dhāraṇī dispels. The translation faithfully renders the incomplete ending.

The epithet "Mistress of the desire realm" renders the Tibetan title indicating she is a sovereign power within the kāmādhātu. Her triple identification as ruler of the desire realm, Mother of Māra, and Sister of Yama places her in a fascinatingly liminal position in this dhāraṇī's framing.

The mantra transliteration follows the Tibetan phonetic rendering as closely as possible; the Sanskrit underlying "vadhōtsi" and "bitiṣṭha" may correspond to forms related to the roots sthā (to stand firm) and vadha (to strike down), but the precise Sanskrit reconstruction is uncertain and the transliteration is left as phonetically rendered in the Tibetan.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.